

Holy Rot

An Anatomy of Fallen Leaves



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Preface

My two years of college life have so far been marked by the quiet presence of one site: the courtyard between the Max Palevsky Central Residential Commons, the Regenstein Library, and Bartlett Dining Hall. While the ornate, faux-Gothic Main Quadrangle may be advertised to prospective students as “the center of campus”, I’d wager it’s actually this unassuming courtyard that is the true heart and soul of UChicago. Whether it’s walking to a friend’s dorm, taking a cigarette break in between study sessions, or running to grab yet another depressing finals week “lunch”, every UChicago student finds themselves here, in this bare-bones, brutalist space, for a significant part of their time in college. Yet, this courtyard is always viewed as a kind of transition—in between classes, in between meals, in between meetings—and not a *place* in its own right, especially by those (like me) who happen to also sleep right next to it. In choosing to focus on this site for my fieldwork, I hope to illustrate the beauty of this overlooked place—no matter how non-obvious—as well as elucidate its thought-provoking ecopoetic potential.

One of this site’s most noticeable and intriguing features, especially during the turn of seasons from autumn to winter, is the abundance of “leaf litter” —that is, the multi-colored sheddings of various tree species, cultivated deliberately for the aesthetic beauty of the university. This detritus—unnoticed, stomped on and torn to pieces by myriad species—turns from green to vibrant red and later dull brown, eventually becoming totally absorbed in the soil and rejuvenating new life in the process. Inspired by Walt Whitman’s “This Compost!”, which presents the beauty and essence of nature as death and decomposition leading into renewal, I felt that such “leaf litter” was a profound microcosm of the kinds of worldwide ecological issues affecting us in the Anthropocene. The everyday strollers who pass through this courtyard—presumably the audience for which it exists to begin with—leave their trash haphazardly displaced amidst the grass, unaware (or uncaring) of its contamination into every last part of the ecosystem. The man-made, the artificial, and the plastic have seeped irrevocably into nature’s cycles of rebirth and death.

In working through the lens of such detritus—what I’ve called “holy rot”—I found not only fallen leaves, but also their intersection with a history of colonization, industrialization, globalization, displacement: a history that has influenced the meaning of the word “home”, as well as my own family history, in uncountably many ways. As in Alison Cobb’s *Plastic: An Autobiography*, I wanted each piece in my collection to communicate some different aspect of these intertwined histories, marrying them together as a demonstration of just how deeply enmeshed human actions and constructs—both the personal and political—are with “the environment”. After all, aren’t we *Homo sapiens* simply one of many groups of organisms who act on and share in the Earth’s global ecosystem?

Thus, my collection begins with a declaration of the Anthropocenic paradigm of leaf litter, inspired by Joyelle McSweeney’s “Toxic Sonnets: A Crown for John Keats”, as well as a map of my site created using John Muir Laws’ method of “soundscapes” (to which the reader can reference throughout). The next is an exploration of the contradictions manifest in fake leaves on fake plants, in the style of Charles Baudelaire and influenced by both IBM’s *Powers of*

Ten and Celeste Olalquiaga's *The Artificial Kingdom*. A commentary on current events is made by cobbling together the markings printed on those leaves formed by dead trees, via CAConrad's 5th (SOMA)tic Poetry Exercise. A brief detour is made to the leafy detritus of a disparate—though nearby—site, using the structure of a “field guide” as in Lisa Robertson's “Site Report: New Brighton Park”. Then, I discuss the role of leaf harvesting in modern foodways: first, in the industrial-scale cultivation of what originated as a spontaneous gift of nature, and second, in modern foraging, challenged by generations of displacement and the systemic destruction of cultural communion with the environment, as demonstrated in Anna Tsing's “Mushroom at the End of the World” and Robin Wall Kimmerer's *Braiding Sweetgrass*. I end, using Deborah Bird Rose's “Shimmer” as inspiration, with what I call a “spatiotemporal translation” of a poem, written by another person in a different language, place, and time, but also centered around autumn's falling leaves.

Finally, I'd like to mention some of the other writers, artists, and poets from whom I've taken especially great inspiration. The organization of my work as an anthology, the use of “(SOMA)tic rituals” in my writing process, and my attention to the shape and structure of text on the page is influenced by CAConrad and their poetry collection *Amanda Paradise*. My use of language and allusion—almost as if amalgamating disparate pieces of “verbal detritus”—is inspired by the wit and wordplay of julie ezelle patton. And of course, I must thank my family, as they have been the greatest influence on the direction of this work.

Sonnets from the 21st-Century Autumn

On pavement, flat, I lie, a freshly fallen leaf,
 once green, once brilliant red, now brown—
 I watch my brethren, maple-colored, upside down
 as swaying brilliance, proud, reflects the past I grieve.
 These *Acer*, *Malus*, *Quercus*, *Tilia*, *Ginkgo* weave
 the scenes of daily life stepped on so often. Found
 by *Sciurus*, plumping up for winter, so I drown
 in dirt, to pieces torn by paws. I'm now debris,
 interred by kicks of dust and feasts by beetles, ants,
 and all those dinner guests too small to recognize.
 And after rain, my parts keep festering: here come
 the earthworms, as all else locked in eternal dance
 of eating, dying, feeding, birth, rebirth—amusing, quite,
 what's said by humans: ashes, ashes, done is done.

What's done is done. My tomb, the incubator, sucks
 the toxic up from soil: the lead, the sewage, particles
 of permanence, too many parts per million. Full
 it grows (and I as well) on sorts of artificial muck
 with barcodes, not names—orderly construct,
 efficient, machinelike, out of long-dead liquid fossils,
 the corpses are transmuted into energy impossible,
 tossed thoughtlessly back down the gullet. O, what luck
 it is that nature lasts and loops continue on!
 embedded deep in my veins, microscopic zombies pulse,
 imbuing me with little-noticed trickle-up lethality.
 Wars that last forever cannot easily be won:
 I eat. I die. I feed. I birth. I rebirth and engulf.
 You can't kill me.

Fake plastic leaves

Within the isolation chamber, my eyes flit (where my feet cannot) to vines: those outside, pane-filtered, ornament the adjacent building—and through a phlegmy haze, become confused with those inside, interwoven with wire-thread, tiny LED bulbs in lieu of buds. *My semi-sick sight cannot distinguish the plastic leaves from the leafy ones. My overheating brain knows they cannot be the same because—*

—because within both there are quarks, electrons, particles, glued at the joints, skeletons... C_nH_{2n+2} daisy-chains... at larger scales, the galvanism of tunnels. *Is only one of these information superhighways, wrapped up in a carbon-based bow, a result of “life”?*—Maybe,

maybe the difference is that the alive ones will fall and detrite and rejoin the soil (maybe even within the next month), and the non-alive ones will remain alive-seeming for another 500 years. Fake plastic leaves cannot return to nature within a generation; instead, they linger on as human memory (*or maybe ignorance?*) persists: kitsch, sinister shadows, non-alive life...

500 years: synthetic kudzu adorns the innards of human housing units everywhere, mimicking nature in the continuing absence of it—some are already bits of landfill... 500 miles away, factories shed sweat—*blood and tears, too*—en masse, servicing the production of a parasitic non-aliveness, one which gorges itself on nature and demands still that more be created—even out of poison—for it to savor ad aeternum. Isn't everything global just a positive feedback loop?

500 years: in 500 years, the same ray of light boring into my too-hot cheeks might strike a different lifeform, not based in carbon, but decaying, rotting in accordance with its alien atmosphere... In 500 years, perhaps some chip of silicon will have evolved consciousness, sentience—*maybe, human-ness*. But can something truly be called “alive”, if it is not able to die?

Within the isolation chamber, I pull a cover over my eyes—but *my gaze, semi-sick, remains transfixed on vines, alive and non-alive.*

HOT OFF THE SHELF—11/6/2024 *(for CA Conrad)*

1. When the Levees Broke

i can only think of levees thinking on it now

BURSTING

the whole thing just fucking bursting

everyone is caught by surprise—but in hindsight
we can only think of the fissures and cracks
been there for months
and only appeared yesterday

2. *Slouching Towards Something*

Did You Know: back in the day,
medieval europeans thought

the corpses of egyptians

[illegible]

perfect human beings
are the most flabbergasting of creatures
i don't know what my invocation is
something in communication is lost
when we become our own captive audience.
my dad is a poet
he writes of rivers and sunsets
does he know the world he wants
is one where the birds don't sing?

they say that youth is beauty
well, *my* youth's been pretty ugly
—i think nothing will be enough
when we remain eating each other.

3. *Jus soli*

sometimes i think i'm a patriot
 because i'll think of the Rocky Mountains
 and the Eastern Seaboard
 and Appalachian forests
 and just be overcome with love
 i want to bathe in all of it and just
 sink into the dirt.
 the Appalachian hills are the withered godparents
 of the young and proud Rockies, and yet
 they will be coeternal.
 for the rivers
 and forests
 and valleys
 and mountains
 and mesas
 and plateaus
 and plains
 will last much longer than we do.
 i want them to evolve past us
 because I'm sure they can
 in ways that we can't.
 the levee is
 BURSTING
 —castration anxiety,
 all
 the
 way
 down,
 now swallowed by the waters.

Field Guide to a Water Dweller

Name: Channel Catfish (*Ictalurus punctatus*)

Age: juvenile (est. 1 month)

Diet: snails, clams, crustaceans, algae, seeds, nuts

Habitat: rivers, reservoirs, lakes, ponds from southern Canada to northern Mexico

Predators: larger fish, birds, humans

Characteristics

Crowned with miniature elk's antlers protruding just above its beady black eyes—a bit too elliptical to be considered pearls—*Ictalurus*'s wide forehead tapers into a translucent, paper-thin tail. A sort of sail is fanned along its back, and three little butterfly wings line the left and right sides. In the water, the baby *Ictalurus* uses these appendages to flit and sway absentmindedly, with a particular youthful whimsy. Its slippery, amorphous body seems somehow to be made of obsidian.

Distribution & Habitat

The Jackson Park of October 31st, 1893 beheld the *World's Columbian Exposition*, a commemoration of the four-hundredth year anniversary of Christopher Columbus's arrival to an island in the Caribbean some thousand or so miles away. Raised high above the Lake Michigan watershed, Jackson—named for the United States' seventh president and belligerent in the Black Hawk War—became a body of water once more, albeit removed from the organized chaos of leaves, reeds, weeds, mud-dwellers, swamp-swimmers—catfish!—fighting together for life. Instead, it was surrounded by the gleaming white of an artificial cityscape, built in the Victorians' image of ancient Rome—catfish!—and destroyed by fire even before the queen herself died.

By the 20th century, Jackson Park could no longer command the world's stares: as the neighborhoods around it deteriorated, so too did its—catfish!—waters, sterilized, then fed, not with the brown bits cast off by overhanging branches, not with grasses and animal—catfish!—droppings, but with urban miasma. Today, however, with renewed rehabilitation, a trickle of people—and a flood of catfish!—returns to Jackson.

Catfish—channel catfish! Not pristine creatures. They are bony, slimy blobs that dwell in the dark. The young begin their lives in the protective arms of mother mud. When humans speak of “restoration”, will they remember their muck-molded, detritus-devouring, ever-essential brethren? Do they know that the catfish have returned home?

LADY GREY(c):

four thousand years ago
 in the country of my parents' birth
 a leaf made its way
 into a man's cup of water

autumn detritus, windswept
 falls like snow around me
 how miraculous it is
 for such rot to become

something like flakes of gold
 bagged up and shipped
 crossing oceans and languages,
 its chauffeurs become wealthy—

Assam and addiction
 Oolong and opium
 Taxed Enough Already,
 in the name of its power

wars and constitutions start
 even now one rages on
 between forest and plantation,
 insect and weed-killer,

where once there was a forest
 with its hybrid litter strewn all across
 now sits a monoculture
 acres and acres, lines drawn between

just to get mixed up together again,
 they call it Fairtrade, and yet
 the boiling resentment remains
 in much the same places. all this,

i think, just to end in my cup,
 Delightfully Blended
 with Bergamot & Lemon Flavours.

5 words for 2 homes

1. Chicago

When Chicago starts making me nauseous, I know it's time to return home. Chicago is bigness. Chicago flexes its towering pillars of Manifest Destiny. Chicago is loud. Chicago screams at you, rattling off a history of Great Men: *LaSalle, Jackson, Cornell*. Really, it's a history of land purchases, over-complicated signatures on over-complicated contracts, futile in their efforts to parcel up something so indivisible as whole ecosystems, but terrifyingly effective in conquering and remolding them.

At times like these, I am grateful for this little corner of the world. Flanked by brutalist fortresses garishly bearing the names of donors, this courtyard remains a nameless but identifiable space. In the nexus between autumn and winter, the trees are bare and detritus blankets the concrete. Try as "landscapers" might to tame it, a corner overgrowth of grasses, herbs—"weeds", perhaps—props its head out from beneath the soil. A block away from the site of the first ever self-sustaining nuclear reaction, two squirrels fight over an oddly-shaped leaf.

2. Long Island

When Grandma moved back, there were two things keeping her sane: fruits and vegetables. We'd drive her an hour out to the specialty grocers so she could pick out golden dragonfruits and mushy pluots, \$10 apiece, too rotten for anyone but her. She replanted her garden, which—save for a stint of renting out to neighbors—soon overflowed with a tangle of grasses, roots, and vines, barely contained by homemade mesh gates. She wasn't humble about it. Despite years of trying, her tongue had rejected the New World's supposed phonemes. But she became fluent in its soil. Kneading it in her hands, she molded our yard into a breeding ground for the flora of her home: ginger, scallions, mustard greens. But many were already home: sweet potatoes, tomatoes, chili peppers. Over centuries, they too had made the circuitous, now never-ending, journey between continents.

3. Shikaakwa

In Algonquian, it means "striped skunk" or "onion". They—the Ojibwe, Odawa, and Potawatomi, the "Council of Three Fires" —named it so for abounding pungence: forested swamp, mired in stink and wafts of distinctive garlicyness. Here, along the banks of the Great Lakes, they traded, both amongst themselves and with the ever-replenishing land.

The stench is different now. The only onions you can smell are remnants of monocultures thousands of miles away—the smoke and grease of food trucks. Chicago is said to have "the

third-largest urban indigenous population in the United States.” This doesn’t reflect the centuries of armed conflict, of displacement and re-displacement, of physical and cultural starvation, a result of unwilling separation from a providing womb. Then, amidst the other “relocations” of World War II, they—the Ojibwe, Odawa, and Potawatomi, the “Council of Three Fires”, the Miami, the Ho-Chunk, the Illinois, and many more—returned to Shikaakwa.

4. Changdao

“I saw some █████ by the road today,” says Grandma.

“Great.” Dad would be disinterested, even if he wasn’t driving.

“I think I should go pick some.”

A grinding halt. “I don’t want you walking around cars so much. And you don’t know if it’s safe to eat, what with all the fumes from the exhaust—”

“But █████ is very nutritious, and it tastes good. I want to make some for you all. And besides, I’m perfectly healthy. For me, walking so much is no big deal...”

The conversation drowns out. I close my eyes, trying to imagine Grandma at age eight: forced from home by the colonial cruelty of a world war, left to fend for seven siblings, how grateful was she upon discovering the hidden edibility of the rural mountainscape which sheltered her? As she weaned from its bounty, did she learn to cultivate it? How did they give to each other?

To this day, I don’t know the specific plant she was talking about. I recall her saying that it was fragrant, with distinctively-shaped leaves. I can only imagine it was some kind of wild onion.

5. Zhijiage

“I’ve been telling your dad to take me to Zhijiage,” says Grandma, over the phone, as I attempt desperately to get three words in.

“I miss you,” she adds. “And I want to see the site of Fermi’s famous discovery.” Unsurprising words from a woman who sold her dowry to become a nuclear physicist. We all live amidst a lingering shadow of some war.

“I know,” I finally say. “I hope to see you soon.” The line cuts out. I walk back inside, trying my hardest not to trample the grasses and the onions and all the once-cherished providers I don’t yet know about beneath my feet.

remnants of '91

alone,
 an autumn leaf—brilliant and golden;
 looked into the distance, there for a long time.
 This little autumn such a rotation,
 choking life and death, coming and going...

wandering souls of many centuries,
 wonderful thoughts, passionate
 holy divine our nature,
 like broken leaves,
 disappearing in the impermanence of history empty hope in vain.
 feel no longer speak...
 a gust of wind and a few seeds
 fell stretched forward
 grabbed stared, and thought
 songs rang out from all directions,
 autumn swayed and
 eager springs kissed
 yes,
 all things rushed in the bleakness of death,
 chasing the perfect existence,
 it will wither in this pursuit;
 still coloring the river of life
 and melting
 —Yes, I have fallen here, I
 am not just an autumn leaf;
 yes, when I understand all this and feel the huge beating of pain, which recurs like the tide, I am
 no longer afraid to
 go down with the River of Oblivion in the boasting of death!

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LADY GREY(c)

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remnants of ‘91

13. Dad—thank you for sending me your poetry (and forgive me for Google Translating it, deleting important lines, and jumbling it up beyond recognition for my creative writing class!). 1991.